

Homelessness in Canada

- What does homelessness mean?

Homelessness means individuals or families lacking stable, safe, and suitable housing. It encompasses people living on the streets, in a homeless shelter, or in temporary accommodation, and people who are “hidden homeless.” (Hidden homelessness means staying temporarily with friends or relatives, in cars, or other precarious situations.)

- What causes homelessness in Canada?

- Homelessness is a significant problem in Canada. Currently, the estimated number of homeless people stands at 235,000 people.
- The main root of homelessness is poverty, that those people who cannot engage with poverty they can become homeless easily. Homeless people also mentioned some other issues too, like emotional or physical abuse, mental illness and addiction issues, domestic violence, loss of employment any many other things.
 - Not having a stable income can lead a person to homelessness.
 - Problems like anxiety, depression are increasing the cause of homelessness.

- How many Homeless People Are There in Canada?

- It is seems impossible to count every homeless, because there are many hidden homeless. In 2021, there were more than 235,000 homeless people in Canada. At the same time moreover, 25,000 to 35,000 people experience homelessness on any given night. In 2005, the federal estimate of the number of homeless in Canada was 200,000, about 1% of the population. Toronto holds the most homeless people in Canada that around 10,000 of homeless people are living there.
- If we only consider 2018, there was 8,700 homeless people around the Canada (533 of them lived in the streets and 6400 of them were staying in shelters).
- A year-long project led by the Lawson Health Research Institute has found that data gaps blur the true picture of homelessness in Canada, preventing rural and remote areas from getting the funding they need for services. The project collected data over the past 12 months from 28 communities across every province and territory in Canada experiencing growing homeless populations.

- PIT (Point In Time) count:

1. On 11 march 2020, at least 1,523 people were experiencing homelessness. According to statistics on homelessness in Canada, there are dispossessed people in every city. However, it has become a major social issue in most urban centres, like Montreal, Vancouver, Calgary, and Edmonton.
2. In a survey that was answered by 428 of the 2,782 individuals counted (15.4%). 179 (22.4%) of those unsheltered completed the survey, and 249 (12.7%) of those sheltered completed the survey

3. 23% of individuals experiencing homelessness have not used an emergency shelter in the past year.
4. Between 2018 and 2022, the number of individuals experiencing homelessness who identified as female increased from 729 (25%) to 883 (32%), whereas those identifying as male decreased from 2,129 (73%) to 1,841 (66%). Rounding out the 2022 count, less than 1% of those surveyed identified as transgender or gender diverse, and 2% did not have a known gender identity. The gender identity of youth and children was relatively even between male and female, with 210 (47.5%) identifying as female and 232 (52.4%) identifying as male. For adult age groups the gender identity skewed male, with 1,286 (69.2%) identifying as male and 559 (30.1%) identifying as female.

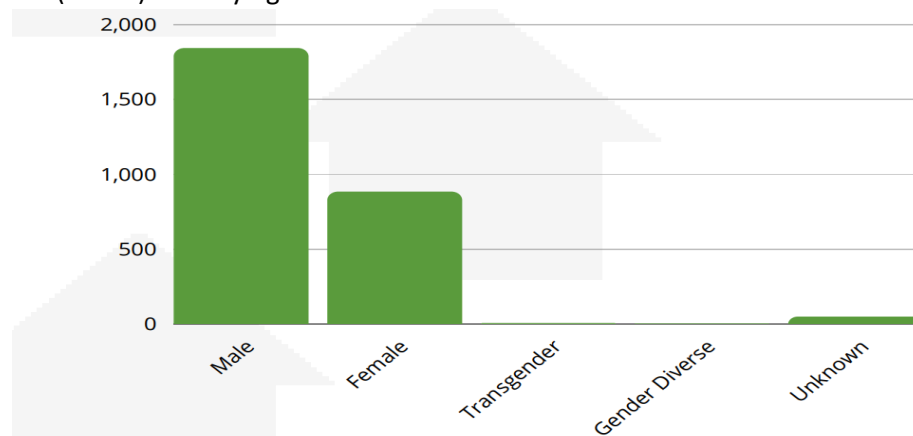


Chart 4 - Gender (Facility Count and Survey Data)

According to 2 sources 235,000 of Canadians are homeless. In 2005 government estimated the number of homeless people 200,000 {1% of the population}.

Homeless people are mostly between 25-49 ages (62% men and 36% women). And the number of children living in shelters was around 3,000.

According to PIT survey in 2016, 23% of homeless people in Vancouver was employed. Only in BC 17,4% of them reported at least one source of income in 2020.

Which city has the most homeless in Canada?

According to 5 sources Toronto has the most homeless with more than 2,615,060 homeless in 2013's report of past 5 years (2007-2013). Calgary was second in chart with homeless population of 1,096,833. Edmonton, Vancouver, Saskatoon, Kelowna.... are after these two cities.

ALBERTA POINT-IN-TIME HOMELESS COUNT

HOMELESSNESS ACROSS SEVEN CITIES

7 CITIES HOMELESS COUNTS

6,663

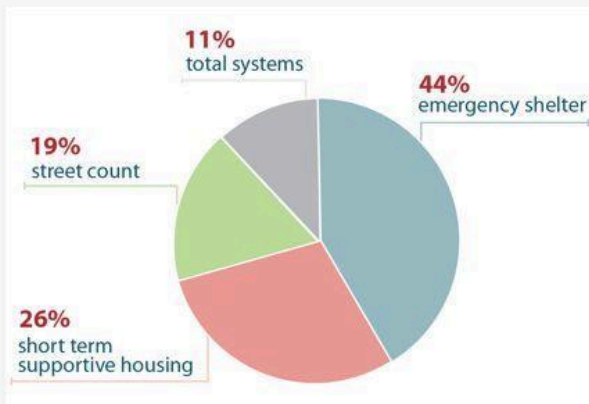
individuals
experiencing
homelessness
across seven
cities.

Calgary	3,555
Edmonton	2,307
Grande Prairie	166
Lethbridge	140
Medicine Hat	64
Red Deer	137
Wood Buffalo	294

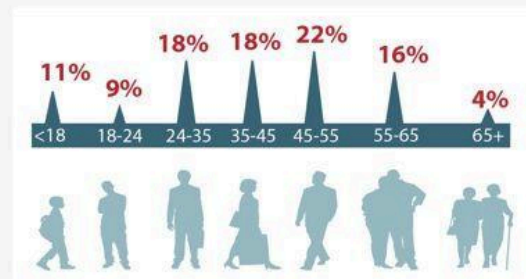


15%
DECREASE since 2008

WHERE ARE PEOPLE STAYING

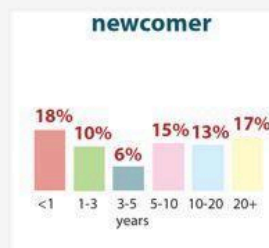
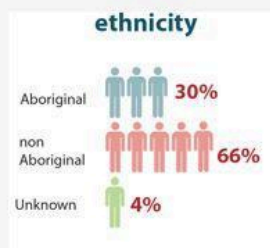


AGE DEMOGRAPHICS



Please note there were different level of responses to different questions and administrative data were used for gender, ethnicity and age. Percentages will not add to 100% as not all categories of responses are included in the infographic.

WHO IS EXPERIENCING HOMELESSNESS



The count was part of an initiative led by the 7 Cities on Housing & Homelessness (7 Cities) in collaboration with the Canadian Observatory on Homelessness to develop a harmonized approach to homeless counts nationally.

Alberta is the first jurisdiction to implement measures towards a more standardized methodology, leading the way in Canada. Though counts across Alberta are becoming more aligned, this is the first time this effort has been undertaken.

If we consider just Alberta through the brochure above from PIT count, we can see that again Calgary had the first position.

Winter and homelessness:



A homeless man in Toronto

Homeless people during winter are facing many issues even death. Frostbite is the common problem, unfortunately the only solution of frostbite is to cut that area and if that area be hand or feet will be another problem in their lives.

Homelessness and illness:

Homeless people are at a higher risk of developing certain health problems like HIV/AIDS, Lung diseases, Malnutrition, Schizophrenia and many other health conditions.

More than 8 out of 10 people (85%) experiencing homelessness reported having chronic health condition. Through the Dr. Stephen W. Hwang's article "homelessness and Health" we got the ten most prominent ones.

- 1- Mortality and unintentional injuries (bruises, cuts, burns, etc...)
- 2- Musculoskeletal disorders and chronic pain. Disorders that affect joints, ligaments and tendons (like arthritis) are common among people experiencing homelessness. One study on managing chronic pain among homeless persons found that treatment is a

challenge due to stressful living on streets or in shelters, inability to afford prescription medications, and poor sleeping conditions.

- 3- **Hunger and nutrition.** Poor nutrition can contribute to a number of chronic conditions over time, and issues like fatigue and weakness in the short term.
- 4- **Skin and foot problems.** People experiencing homelessness are often out and about for long periods of time, sometimes in ill-fitting shoes and worn-out socks. As Dr. Hwang notes; “Foot disorders such as onychomycosis, tinea pedis, corns and callouses, and immersion foot are usually the result of inadequate footwear, prolonged exposure to moisture, long periods of walking and standing, and repetitive minor trauma.”
- 5- **Infectious diseases.** People who are homeless are often at risk of infectious diseases—like hepatitis A, B, and C, tuberculosis, and HIV/AIDS—due to compromised immune systems, poor nutrition and hygiene, and frequent overcrowding at shelters.
- 6- **Dental problems.**
- 7- **Respiratory illness.** Chronic obstructive pulmonary disease, emphysema, bronchitis and other forms of respiratory disease are also common among people experiencing homelessness.
- 8- **Chronic diseases and disorders.** Many chronic diseases and disorders, like hypertension and diabetes, are common in homeless populations. In one 2006 study, 49.3% of people in the sample group were diagnosed with epilepsy and 40.7% with alcohol-related seizures.
- 9- **Sexual and reproductive care.**
- 10- **Mental health issues.**

Trough to Dr. Stephen W. Hwang’s article we know the common illnesses of homeless people. Probably there is more and more diseases because of bad hygiene and many other things.

Mental issues like depression and anxiety is the first encourager of people to use drugs and after that that person will like that way and continue. I can also mention about financial problems, bad finance and not having enough for daily life is another issue that lead people to drugs.

Countries with high amount of homeless people should find a solution to stop people from using anything that could lead their people to addiction. Making more jobs is a good way to keep people away, or preparing more homes for low-income families is the other thing.

For those people who are addicted, governments should help them to leave their addiction and start a new life with their loved ones. Mentally help is the first step, they should be ensure of their future like job and place to live. Preparing a stable job and payment has a good role in keeping people away.

Preventing from Homelessness:

Cutting unnecessary expenses, start saving, knowing how to spend your money, trying to have a better mental health and many other things are another way of avoiding homelessness.

Research on homelessness prevention demonstrates that prevention strategies succeed in reducing homelessness. For example, Pawson’s evaluation of prevention strategies in Scotland

found that tenancy supports, such as landlord mediation, housing advice, and family mediation, greatly contributed to decreases in eviction. Furthermore, research shows the effectiveness of discharge planning and transitional supports from mental health hospitals, correctional facilities, and shelters as homelessness prevention strategies.

Conclusion:

Homelessness is a big issue in many countries nowadays. Root of homelessness is poverty and dealing with this problem is on governments. Preventing from homelessness is on both self and governments. Keeping a good mental health, start savings try to not spend money on unnecessary things is some of the things on us. Making homes for low incomes, providing more jobs, help the low income families,... are those things that are on governments.

Written by Murwarid Poyan.